intentions, Castro had a column of children parade through the streets of Havana in a formation that read, “Long Live Our Socialist Revolution.”[6]

Scarred by the Bay of Pigs invasion and expecting a much more powerful invasion in the near future, Castro apparently believed that to save his revolution he had to turn it into a socialist one. He badly needed socialist solidarity and wanted it to come not only in the form of Soviet purchases of sugar, trade credits for Soviet equipment, and supplies of oil. He also wanted weapons, missiles in particular. In his letter of September 4, 1961, Castro asked Moscow for 388 surface-to-air missiles like the one that had shot down the American U-2 airplane in May 1960 over the Soviet Union. His overall request for military assistance amounted to US $200 million. The Soviets were open to the idea but reduced the aid package to approximately $150 million. They also dragged their feet on delivery. Khrushchev was taking his time.[7]

Before the end of the year, the desperate Castro had declared himself a Marxist and a Leninist. On December 2, 1961, he delivered a speech that directly engaged some of the statements made by Khrushchev at the “builders of communism” congress a month earlier. Castro referred to Khrushchev’s report to the congress as evidence that Marxism was a living and developing ideology. He pointed out that Marx did not leave a blueprint for building a socialist society. In Castro’s reading of Marx, every anti-imperial revolution was a socialist one. “There could have been only one anti-imperialist and socialist Revolution, because there is but one revolution,” he declared.[8]

The speech raised the ideological stakes in relations between the Soviet Union and Cuba. Castro declared himself a Marxist-Leninist, or a Marxist of the Soviet type—someone who had read Marx and Lenin in his student days but had come to a full appreciation of their works only recently. While American newspapers had a field day commenting on Castro’s declaration of his Marxist beliefs, claiming to have known all along that Castro was a communist, the Soviet media were much more reserved.

In Moscow Castro was still regarded as part of a broad group of Third World leaders who opposed imperialism. “Statesmen as different as the popular hero of Cuba, Fidel Castro, and President Sukarno of Indonesia, Prime Minister Nehru of India and President Nkrumah of Ghana turn to the